

When I am you: Deriving honorifics through weak indices *

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1. Introduction

Addressee honorifics are pronouns that refer to the addressee on the truth-condition layer (TC) while, simultaneously, conveying some kind of social or psychological distance between the speaker (s_c) and the addressee (a_c) as a conventionalized use-condition (UC) (Iwasaki and Horie 2000, McCready 2019, Varaschin et al. 2024, i.a.). Some examples illustrating the same pairing of TC/UC in well-known European languages are given in (1).

- (1) a. *Avez vous pris vos médicaments?* (French)
have.2.PL 2.PL taken your.PL medicine.PL
- b. *Lei ha preso le medicine?* (Italian)
3.SG.F have.3.SG taken the medicine.PL
- c. *Haben Sie Ihre Medikamente genommen?* (German)
have.3.PL 3.PL your.PL medicine.PL taken
TC: $\{\lambda w. a_c \text{ took } a_c\text{'s medicine in } w, \lambda w. \neg(a_c \text{ took } a_c\text{'s medicine in } w)\}$
UC: $\{c : s_c \text{ and } a_c \text{ are (socially or psychologically) distant in } c\}$

In each of these cases, the form used for honorific a_c -reference is recruited from elsewhere in the language's pronominal paradigm. In French, it is the 2PL pronoun *vous*; in Italian, it is the 3SG feminine pronoun *Lei*; while in German, the equivalent honorific form is the 3PL form *Sie*. The main question addressed in this paper is whether the morphosyntactic features recruited for a_c -honorification exhibit systematic cross-linguistic patterns and, if so, what is the best explanation for this regularity?

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Wang (2023, 2024, 2025) proposes a presupposition-based pragmatic account to predict the possible candidates for honorific forms from the interaction between Maximize Presupposition! and the Taboo of Directness. In her account, honorific forms are realized by semantically weaker ϕ -features, i.e. with less presuppositional strength, such as 3rd rather than 1st, or PL instead of SG. In this paper, we contend that Wang’s account cannot be maintained in its current form. We propose an account that reconciles Wang’s pragmatic insight with conventional approaches. We argue that honorific meanings are parasitic on conventionalized use-conditions, but that these conditions are not arbitrary; rather, they are motivated by a general pragmatic principle favoring the use of weak indices for the expression of social or psychological distance. The proposal treats person (PER) and number (NUM) as components of complex anaphoric indices (Pollard and Sag 1994, Sudo 2012, Varaschin and Machicao y Priemer 2025), rather than as presupposition-triggering ϕ -heads.

In Section 2, we first summarize Wang’s presuppositional account. Sections 3.1 and 3.2 then present some puzzles for Wang’s theory. In Section 4, we develop our alternative proposal based on an explicitness order over indices, and Section 5 concludes the paper.

2. A presupposition-based pragmatic account

In Wang (2023, 2024, 2025), honorific forms are argued to arise from the interaction between two pragmatic maxims: Maximize Presupposition! (MP!; Heim 1991, cf. (2a)) and the Taboo of Directness (ToD; Wang 2023, cf. (2b)).

- (2) a. **MP!:** Use the form with the strongest presupposition.
- b. **ToD:** In respect contexts, use the form with the weakest presupposition.

Wang (2023) argues honorification exhibits a strong cross-linguistic tendency to recycle existing morphosyntactic features (cf. Corbett 2012). In particular, her survey of 90 languages found that PL and 3rd person are consistently recruited for the expression of politeness, as highlighted in a gray background color in Table 1.

	SG	PL
1	1SG	1PL
2	2SG	2PL
3	3SG	3PL

Table 1: Feature bundles recruited for a_c -honorification

This striking cross-linguistic regularity is *prima facie* puzzling for theories that attribute honorific meanings to linguistic convention alone, e.g., via a dedicated syntactic feature such as [HON] (Portner et al. 2019, i.a.); it is also puzzling for theories that attribute honorificity to the lexical meanings of specific a_c -referring forms, as in *conventional implicature* approaches (Potts and Kawahara 2004, McCready 2019, i.a.). As an alternative, Wang (2023) proposes a pragmatic account, where honorific meanings emerge from a general principle that motivates the use of presuppositionally weaker features to convey politeness.

Wang’s account builds on analyses according to which certain ϕ features are semantically more marked (i.e. stronger) than others in virtue of their presuppositional content, e.g. $[\text{SG}] < [\text{PL}]$; $[\text{1}]$ or $[\text{2}] < [\text{3}]$ (Sauerland 2008, i.a.). These proposals are motivated, for instance, by data such as (3), which show that $[\text{PL}]$ lacks a cardinality restriction in contrast to $[\text{SG}]$, cf. (4); and that $[\text{3}]$ can include s_c or a_c , whereas $[\text{1}]$ and $[\text{2}]$ are more restricted, cf. (5). On this view, honorific meanings emerge, *as per* ToD, when a presuppositionally weaker form, e.g. $[\text{3}]$, is used to refer to an entity that (under MP!) would more directly be identified by a strong form, e.g. $[\text{2}]$. The account thus provides a formal explanation for the intuition that polite behavior is achieved by avoiding direct reference (cf. Brown and Levinson 1987).

- (3) a. There are *no books* on the table.
b. [Every one of us]₁ has to call $\{his_1 / *my_1 / *your_1\}$ mother.
- (4) a. $[[\text{SG}]] = \lambda x : |x| = 1.x$
b. $[[\text{PL}]] = \lambda x.x$
- (5) a. $[[\text{1}]] = \lambda x : s_c \subseteq x.x$
b. $[[\text{2}]] = \lambda x : a_c \subseteq x.x$
c. $[[\text{3}]] = \lambda x.x$

To account for the cross-linguistic variation in honorific forms illustrated in (1), Wang further decomposes ToD into separate constraints on number and person (Wang 2024, 2025). By reranking of MP!, ToD_{NUM}, and ToD_{PER}, the analysis derives the range of polite-address patterns in her large cross-linguistic sample, cf. (6). For instance, in polite registers of French, ToD_{NUM} outranks MP!, which in turn outranks ToD_{PER}, yielding the 2PL form as the semantically weaker option for polite address. In Italian, by contrast, it is the person feature that leads to the weaker form. In German, both ToD_{PER} and ToD_{NUM} outrank MP!, resulting in the 3PL form as the realization of polite address. In English, however, MP! outranks both ToD constraints, leaving no dedicated honorific form available.

- (6) a. (Polite) French: ToD_{NUM} >> MP! >> ToD_{PER} $\leadsto$ *vous*_{2PL}
b. (Polite) Italian: ToD_{PER} >> MP! >> ToD_{NUM} $\leadsto$ *Lei*_{3SG}
c. (Polite) German: ToD_{PER}, ToD_{NUM} >> MP! $\leadsto$ *Sie*_{3PL}
d. English: MP! >> ToD_{PER}, ToD_{NUM} $\leadsto$ $\emptyset$

Nevertheless, we argue that this approach requires refinement for two logically independent reasons. First, the symmetry Wang assumes between the presuppositional strength of 1st and 2nd person pronouns is empirically untenable (Zwicky 1977, Cysouw 2005, Bobaljik and Sauerland 2023), cf. Sec. 3.1. Second, and more importantly, the presupposition-based pragmatic account both under- and overgenerates in crucial cases, cf. Sec. 3.2.

3. Some puzzles

In this section, we present some puzzles that are hard to reconcile with the account of honorifics presented in Section 2. These puzzles come in two sets, each of which is logically independent from the other, but both jointly motivate our own proposal in Section 4.

3.1 The puzzles of first-person honorifics

The first set of puzzles concerns the semantic relation between the presuppositions Wang (2023) assigns to person features. In particular, we critically examine the claim that 1st and 2nd person are semantically symmetrical, see (5a) & (5b), insofar as both are taken to presuppose the inclusion of one of the discourse participants (either s_c or a_c). This proposal fails to capture an important asymmetry in reference to pluralities containing s_c and a_c . As illustrated in (7), 1st person may include a_c , whereas 2nd never includes s_c . Under the representation in (5), however, both patterns are incorrectly predicted to be possible.

- (7) [Du und ich]₁ müssen {*unsere*₁ / **eure*₁} Freunde anrufen. (German)
you and I must POSS.1.PL POSS.2.PL friends call
‘[You and I]₁ have to call {our₁ / *your_{PL1}} friends.’

This is not merely a lexical idiosyncrasy of German possessive pronouns. Typologically, we observe a robust generalization whereby reference to pluralities containing both s_c and a_c is never realized by a 2nd person form (e.g. **you*), as illustrated in Table 2 (Zwicky 1977, Harbour 2016, Bobaljik and Sauerland 2023). Wang’s (2023) symmetric system in (5) cannot derive this restriction without additional assumptions.

Plurality including	Mandarin Chinese	English	Unattested
s_c , but not a_c	women	we	*swe
$s_c + a_c$	zamen	we	*syou
a_c , but not s_c	nimen	you	*syou

Table 2: Clusivity patterns

Wang’s (2023) motivation for positing a symmetric relation between 1st and 2nd person is primarily empirical: her vast typological survey uncovered no cases in which either 1st or 2nd person forms are recruited for honorification. However, even English appears to provide potential counterexamples, which are also noted by Wang (2025). Most notable are uses of 1PL forms in contexts where the s_c is performing the role of a caretaker toward one or more a_c s – a phenomenon often referred to as *Nurse We* (Collins and Postal 2012) – see (8).

- (8) Have *we*_{1=*you*} taken our₁ medicine today? [s_c is taking care of at least one a_c]

If a_c is part of a plurality (i.e., if s_c is addressing multiple a_c s), the honorific interpretation of (8) is not predicted under Wang’s system, since the unmarked number form, i.e. PL, would be required given the properties of the referent alone. If, on the other hand, the reference is atomic, then (8) violates the presupposition in (5a), because $g(1)$ would not include the s_c in that context. Atomic a_c -reference with 1PL can actually be enforced through the use of the reflexive *ourselves*, as in (9) – a fact Wang’s approach cannot account for.

- (9) *We*_{1=*you*} have to take good care of *ourselves*₁! [s_c is taking care of a single a_c]

A similar case is found in Japanese, where the 1SG pronoun *boku* may be used when the s_c addresses a child, with condescending undertones (McCready 2007), as in (10).

- (10) *boku*_{=you}-wa horensoo-ga kirai na n? (Japanese)
 1.SG-TOP spinach-NOM dislike COP Q
 ‘Don’t you like spinach?’

Wang (2025:87–88) questions whether examples such as these genuinely involve honorification. Traditionally, honorifics have been understood as expressions associated with meanings of respect, formality, or politeness, and it is not obvious that this extends to cases like (8)–(10). At the same time, derogatory expressions (e.g. Japanese *yagaru* or Thai *mung*) have also been analyzed as (anti-)honorific (Potts and Kawahara 2004, McCready 2019, i.a.). On this broader conception, honorific expressions are associated with registers marked for particular degrees of formality, whether toward the aggressively formal or the aggressively informal end of the spectrum, as in the anti-honorific cases. We adopt this broader definition and treat as honorific any form that encodes an interpersonal relation involving a particular degree of (social or psychological) distance between s_c and some other individual, the a_c in the cases of interest to us here. Under this view, Nurse *We* indicates a context in which the speaker s_c licenses themselves to address the addressee a_c informally, typically because s_c occupies a higher position in the social hierarchy relative to a_c – by virtue of their position as caretaker, or more generally because they assume the asymmetric power relations associated with that role. Similar considerations apply to *boku* in (10), whose felicity also requires a difference in social hierarchy to hold between s_c and a_c .

There is also empirical motivation for adopting this broader valence- and formality-neutral definition of honorificity. Cross-linguistically, the recruitment of ϕ -features for the expression of politeness and impoliteness appears to have the same targets. This can be seen in cases of impolite or condescending a_c -reference involving, e.g., 1PL (11a) or 3SG forms (11b). (We thank Nina Haslinger (p.c.) for drawing our attention to these cases.)

- (11) a. Are *we* stupid? [condescending]
 b. Isn’t *he* cute! [infantilizing]

Because ToD (2b) is restricted to contexts of respect or politeness, it fails to generalize to these anti-honorific uses of ϕ -features. By contrast, the broader notion of honorificity adopted here (cf. (18)), straightforwardly extends to these phenomena and to Nurse *We*, as they all conventionally express a particular professional or power relationship between speaker and addressee, e.g. *patient–provider*, and thereby convey a specific kind of distance. It remains unclear whether anti-honorific uses of 1PL such as (11a) constitute a different phenomenon or instead represent an extension of Nurse *We*. Although the two may differ distributionally, space limitations prevent a conclusive discussion here. In any case, a valence-neutral version of ToD coupled with the weak semantics for 1st person we propose in Section 4 is capable of analyzing these cases too, because they license the literal use of the 1st person feature to refer to the a_c . The same holds for the 3rd person in (11b). As a result, these anti-honorific patterns follow without requiring any additional machinery.

Even setting these cases aside, 1PL can be recruited for core respect-based honorification in a number of languages, especially in the Austronesian family, cf. Table 3 (Brown and Levinson 1987, Cysouw 2005, Fleming 2017, Choksi 2021, Akolkar 2024).¹ However, 2nd person is never recruited for honorification of any kind. This pattern suggests that the symmetry between 1st and 2nd person must be broken (cf. Harley and Ritter 2002).

Family	Languages
Austronesian	Muna, Konjo, Bajau, Wolio, Sa'dan, Makassarese, Bugis, Banggai, Tukang Besi, Bimanese, Old Javanese, Tetun, Malagasy, Hawaiian, i.a.
Austroasiatic	Santali
Sino-Tibetan	Limbu
Uto-Aztecan	Guarijío
Quechuan	Cuzco Quechua
Indo-Aryan	Marathi
Dravidian	Tamil
Isolate	Ainu

Table 3: Languages with 1PL as core honorific strategy

3.2 Undergeneration and overgeneration issues

The second set of puzzles concerns broader architectural features that define the type of pragmatic presupposition-based account proposed by Wang (2023, 2024, 2025).

As formulated in (2b), ToD predicts only that certain expressions are licensed in polite contexts. However, as already mentioned, forms recruited to convey politeness can as well be used to imply impoliteness, as in (11), where ϕ -features are used to convey condescension and infantilization in an insulting way. This is possible because social distance and hierarchy between the interlocutors is the crucial unifying factor for honorifics.

However, fine-grained social role restrictions that are not derivable from abstract social hierarchy and distance considerations also attach to (anti-)honorific forms. Pragmatic principles like ToD fail to capture these as well. For example, a speaker of Nurse *We* does not merely present themselves as distant, or as above a_c in the social hierarchy. They also present themselves, specifically, as a ‘caretaker’. This is why Nurse *We* only sounds acceptable in (12a) if we assume a caretaking scenario (e.g. the interlocutor displays the symptoms of a virus that is spreading through Italy). This reading is not as readily available for (12b), which sounds anomalous as a result. The issue is not the presence of *ever*, but whether the content of the speech act is plausible in a caretaking context, as (12c) shows.

- (12) a. Have $we_{=you}$ been to Italy?
b. #Have $we_{=you}$ ever been to Italy?
c. Have $we_{=you}$ ever been tested for diabetes?

¹Most of these are inclusive 1PL forms, but not all of them; see the Bugis example in Cysouw (2005:225).

In this respect, the pragmatic-presuppositional account undergenerates: it fails to predict the correlation between (anti-)honorific interpretations and these fine-grained role-dependent use-conditional meanings required for felicity in a specific context. These meanings are also cross-linguistically variable. For example, in German, it is possible for doctors to use 3SG pronouns to address their patients (e.g. *Er_{=you} sollte mehr schlafen*), but the equivalent sounds quite odd in English (**He_{=you} should sleep more*). These language-specific arbitrary restrictions would also need to be stipulated in a ToD-based account.

Furthermore, honorific meaning behaves like lexically anchored use-conditional meaning, instead of presuppositions with respect to ellipsis. As discussed by various authors, expressive meanings (the prototypes of use-conditional content) are invisible in such contexts, as (13) shows (Potts et al. 2009, McCready 2019, i.a.).

- (13) A: I saw your fucking dog in the park.
B: No you didn't – you couldn't have. The poor thing passed away last week.

As expected if honorifics involve conventional use-conditions, we observe the kinds of honorific effects considered in this paper to disappear in such contexts. But this doesn't follow from Wang's view, on which those effects are the result of pragmatic competition between forms; this kind of competition isn't affected by surface realization, and so should remain available in ellipsis contexts, contrary to fact, as the German case in (14) shows.

- (14) a. CONTEXT: [Peter, a stranger, says to Clara:]
Meine Mutter kann Ihnen_{=you} helfen.
my mother can 3PL.DAT.HON help
'My mother can help you_{HON}' ~ Peter and Clara are distant
- b. CONTEXT: [Katie, Clara's best friend, says to Clara:]
Ich kann auch ~~(Ihnen_{=you} helfen)~~!
I can too 3PL.DAT.HON help
'I can too.' ~ no implication of distance between Katie and Clara

There are other reasons to think that honorific content as a whole can't follow from general pragmatic principles such as ToD. The most obvious is the idiosyncratic nature of honorification, which expresses differently in different languages: while many languages exhibit the recruitment of ϕ -features for honorification in a way that is amenable to ToD analyses, in others honorification is associated with dedicated lexical items or paradigms (see McCready 2019 for extensive discussion). Some languages don't exhibit honorification at all. It therefore strikes us as implausible that a universal mechanism of pragmatic comparison is at play across the entire range of human languages, which supports, at minimum, the use of other mechanisms in addition to a pragmatic, presuppositional one.

A final empirical problem involves overgeneration. Nothing prevents ToD from applying to lower ranked items in other putative presuppositional scales involving 'marked' forms. The items/features deployed in (15), for instance, have all been argued to be presuppositionally weaker than some structurally comparable alternative (e.g. MASC vs. FEM).

- (15) a. **Gender:** Is *he* happy? [referring to female a_c]
b. **Non-factive verbs:** My mother *believes* that I am Brazilian.
c. **Misplaced Indefinites:** Let's go outside and sit in *a sun*.

But no known language expresses a_c -honorification by such means. Not all presuppositionally weak forms are recruitable. Intuitively, all that should matter is *referential explicitness* – i.e. the degree to which the honorific form narrows down the set of its possible referents. PERSON and NUMBER-features on pronouns directly constrain reference to the ‘honored’ entity, while weakness in gender, factivity, or definiteness in the ‘wrong’ DP do not do this.

In the next section, we turn to our own proposal, which alters and enriches the theory in order to solve the puzzles laid out in the course of this section.

4. Explicitness, Indices and Honorifics

In this section, we propose an account that formalizes the intuition that honorific recruitment is pragmatically driven by referential explicitness, but must be conventionally anchored by language-specific use-conditions (UCs). Our goal is to reconcile pragmatic accounts of honorification like Wang (2023) with conventional ones (McCready 2019).

The first step is to come up with a notion of referential explicitness that disentangles the contribution of person (π) and number ($\#$) features from presuppositions. Building on work on bound indexicals (Sudo 2012, Varaschin and Machicao y Priemer 2025) and definites (Chaiphet and Jenks 2021), we assume that π and $\#$ are part of the syntactic representation of anaphoric indices, which are, thus, defined as $\langle n, [\phi] \rangle$ pairs, with $[\phi]$ a set of π and $\#$, for any $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Once we adopt this, the semantic import of π and $\#$ need not be framed presuppositionally, but can live in the metalanguage of assignments, constrained by (16).²

(16) **Constraint on Assignment Functions:**

A function g from indices to D_e is an *admissible assignment function* for a complete utterance u in a context c iff for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$:

- a. $s_c \sqsubseteq g(\langle n, [\mathbb{I}] \rangle) \vee a_c \sqsubseteq g(\langle n, [\mathbb{I}] \rangle)$
b. $s_c \not\sqsubseteq g(\langle n, [\mathbb{I}] \rangle) \wedge a_c \sqsubseteq g(\langle n, [\mathbb{I}] \rangle)$
c. $g(\langle n, [\mathbb{SG}] \rangle) \in \text{ATOM}(D_e)$

This system allows us to define containment relations within the range of admissible values for indices according to their features. We illustrate this with the semilattices for indices containing 1st, 2nd and 3rd person features in Figure 1, where o stands for any individual other than s_c and a_c . Note that 3rd person lacks any restriction.

As Figure 1 shows, some indices come out as more explicit than others (i.e. more restricted w.r.t. their possible values) depending on the ϕ -features they carry; e.g. $\langle 7, [\mathbb{2SG}] \rangle$ is more explicit than $\langle 5, [\mathbb{3PL}] \rangle$ because the latter can be assigned to any entity in D_e , whereas the former can only be assigned to a_c . We define the explicitness relation formally in (17).

²The constraints we propose in (16) closely track the ones in Sudo (2012:180), with the difference that we assume, following work on ϕ markedness, that 3rd person and PL introduce no restrictions of their own.

- (17) For every $n \in \mathbb{N}$ and ϕ -feature sets ϕ, ϕ' , a complex index $\langle n, \boxed{\phi'} \rangle$ is *more explicit* than $\langle n, \boxed{\phi} \rangle$ iff $\{x | \exists g \text{ such that } g(\langle n, \boxed{\phi'} \rangle) = x\} \subset \{x | \exists g \text{ such that } g(\langle n, \boxed{\phi} \rangle) = x\}$

We use this notion of explicitness to replace the notion of presuppositional strength in Wang (2023). Combined with (16), this allows us to define a new markedness hierarchy for PERSON, where $\boxed{2} < \boxed{1} < \boxed{3}$. In other words, 2nd person comes out as the most marked among π values. Our analysis denies, therefore, the symmetry between 1st and 2nd person. We lay out the partial explicitness order over indices (and its honorific import) in Figure 2. Our PERSON ordering also reflects the order of pronoun acquisition (Moyer et al. 2015).

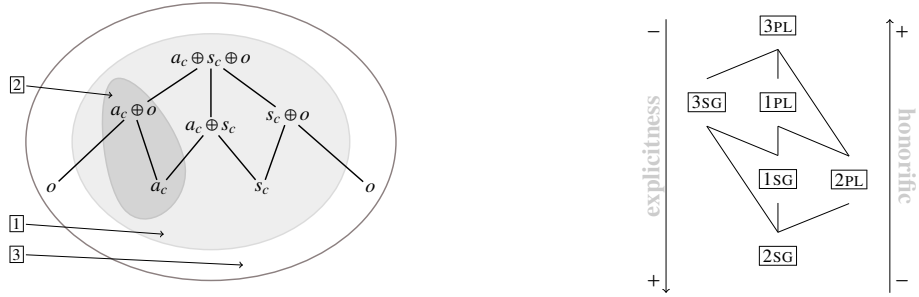


Figure 1: Semilattices: $\boxed{1}$, $\boxed{2}$ & $\boxed{3}$ indices Figure 2: Partial order of explicitness on ϕ -sets

Note that (16b) encodes the typological restrictions on clusivity observed in Section 3: any form including s_c as a possible referent can only be realized as 1st person. Our weak semantics for $\boxed{1}$ also correctly derives that 1st person forms can have singular a_c -only readings; cf. the singular Nurse We (9) and Japanese *boku* facts in (10).³ These are empirical advantages over Wang’s symmetric system independent of one’s theory of honorification.⁴

Regarding honorification, we assume a dual system that combines a pragmatic and a conventional component. The latter consists of UC constraints on classes of assignments,

³One may wonder whether Nurse We could be analyzed as an imposter structure where covert 2SG features are merged onto a 1PL source (Collins and Postal 2012). This would undermine our theory, because we take Nurse We to suggest that a_c must be in the range of $\boxed{1}$. However, we do not think this is the case. Unlike plural imposters (e.g. *Mommy and Daddy*), plural Nurse We does not allow person mismatches in binding:

- (i) a. Are we₁ taking good care of {ourselves₁ / * yourselves₁} today?
b. Mommy and Daddy₁ are taking care of {themselves₁ / ourselves₁}.

Furthermore, a_c -referring uses of 1PL support bound-variable readings under *only*: (iia) has a salient reading paraphrasable as ‘no other patient x ate x ’s breakfast’ in a context where one is talking to a patient, while (iib) lacks the parallel reading on which s_c together with some other individual is the binder.

- (ii) a. Only we₁ ate our₁ breakfast.
b. Only we₁ ate Mommy and Daddy₁’s breakfast.

⁴Our theory derives the typological pattern, but the presence of a negative condition $s_c \notin g(\langle n, \boxed{2} \rangle)$ might raise some suspicions. It would be desirable to restate (16b) as simply $a_c \in g(\langle n, \boxed{2} \rangle)$ and to derive the negative conjunct from independent principles. One idea is to invoke a ‘typicality’ preference (similar to Levinson’s (2000) I-Principle) that favors indices containing $\boxed{1}$ for s_c reference on the grounds that the range of $\boxed{1}$ is more ‘speaker-heavy’ than $\boxed{2}$ would be (even if it did not exclude s_c). We leave this idea for future work.

which we elaborate on below. The former is based on the valence- and formality-neutral version of ToD stated in terms of *weak indices* in (18), already hinted at in Section 3.1.

- (18) **Taboo of Distance** (ToDi): To convey distance between s_c and an entity ε (regardless of valence or formality), use a weak index with ε as a possible value

ToDi correctly derives the honorific uses of 1PL to refer to a plurality of interlocutors, which posed a challenge to Wang’s theory, cf. (8). Because it is only sensitive to *weak indices*, ToDi also avoids overgenerating honorific meanings in cases like (15). In other words, ToDi captures the intuition that honorificity draws from referential inexplicitness, as opposed to other forms of semantic weakness, like presuppositional underspecification.

When coupled with the constraint on assignments in (16), ToDi makes the following typological predictions, made visible in the honorific ordering in Figure 2:

- Every language should conventionalize more ϕ -featural means for a_c -honorification than for honorification of other individuals (see also Wang 2024:12).
- There is no recruitment of ϕ -features for honorification of pluralities consisting of non-discourse participants (e.g. a 2PL being used as an honorific for an *o*-group)
- Pluralities containing s_c but not a_c can only be ϕ -featurally honored by 3PL forms.
- In systems with multiple honorific tiers differing in ϕ -features, the rank of each tier is expected to follow the degree of compliance with ToDi: e.g. if a language has a_c -honorifics in both 3SG and 3PL, the latter should be more honorific than the former.⁵

The need for a conventional component in our account becomes clear when we consider how ToDi interacts with general concerns about informativity in language use. If we assume that speakers should be as informative as possible (as per Quantity), they should aim to use the most explicit index available to them. This seems to be at odds with the prescription established by ToDi – this was the reasoning that led Wang (2023) to propose maxim reranking between ToD and MP!. We argue, however, that this conflict is only apparent. The two principles target distinct dimensions of meaning: ToDi is sensitive to the *explicitness of indices*, a property of the range of admissible assignments, while the Maxim of Quantity in (19) is sensitive to *informativity*, which we define over both the truth-conditional ($\llbracket \cdot \rrbracket_t$) and use-conditional ($\llbracket \cdot \rrbracket_u$) layers of meaning (McCready 2010, Gutzmann 2015). The UC of a sentence S is defined as the set of contexts where S is felicitous (Kaplan 1999, i.a.).

- (19) **Maxim of Quantity** (MQ): Do not use a structure σ if there is another structure $\sigma' \in \text{ALT}_Q(\sigma)$ s.t.: (i) σ' is more informative than σ , and (ii) σ' is assertable.

⁵The latter seems to be compatible with the multi-tiered systems in some Indo-Aryan languages (Wang 2024). Our asymmetric approach to 1st and 2nd persons also predicts that, in languages that conventionalize both 1PL and 2PL forms as a_c -honorifics, the former should always count as more honorific than the latter. This seems to be confirmed by some varieties of Tamil, where the 1PL form *nām* has been described as ‘super-honorific’ while the 2PL *nīṅkaḷ* is defined as a ‘regular honorific’ (Brown and Levinson 1987:202).

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- a. $\text{ALT}_Q(\sigma) = \{\sigma' : \sigma' \text{ is at most as complex as } \sigma\}$ ⁶
- b. σ' is *more informative* than σ iff both
 - (i) $\{w : \exists g \text{ s.t. } \llbracket \sigma' \rrbracket_t^g(w) = 1\} \subset \{w : \exists g \text{ s.t. } \llbracket \sigma \rrbracket_t^g(w) = 1\}$
 - (ii) $\llbracket \sigma' \rrbracket_u^g \subset \llbracket \sigma \rrbracket_u^g$

In our version of MQ, clause (19b.i) quantifies over admissible assignments, so a structure counts as more informative when its index is more explicit. The crucial feature of (19), however, is that *informativity* is defined conjunctively across dimensions: σ' counts as more informative than σ only if content containment holds on *both* the TC and UC levels. This means that a weak index cannot be supplanted by a more explicit alternative if it carries UC content that the alternative lacks – even if the alternative is more informative at the TC layer alone. This is precisely the loophole exploited by ϕ -featurally derived honorifics.

We propose that honorific weak indices are licensed by language-specific UC constraints (UCCs) on assignment functions. A UCC associates sets of assignments with particular classes of contexts; e.g. the UCC associated with Nurse We can be stated as in (20).

$$(20) \quad \text{For any } \llbracket u \rrbracket^{g,c}, \text{ if } g(\langle n, \boxed{\text{1PL}} \rangle) = a_c, \text{ then } c \in \{c : s_c \text{ takes care of } a_c\}$$

This UCC restricts the use of an a_c -referring 1PL index to contexts in which s_c stands in a caretaking role with respect to a_c . Since this implies distance, ToDi is satisfied. Crucially, the UC restriction enriches the informational content of the weak index, so that the relation between the weak form and its more explicit alternative is no longer a containment relation on both meaning dimensions. While 2SG is more informative than 1PL on the TC dimension (since it can only refer to a_c -inclusive entities), 1PL strengthened by (20) is more informative on the UC dimension (since 2SG carries no analogous restriction). By the conjunctive definition in (19b), neither structure counts as more informative than the other, and MQ does not rule out the weak alternative. Similar considerations hold for Japanese *boku* and all other honorifics: assignments that would be deemed non-optimal by MQ on TC-grounds are licensed via enriched UCs.⁷ Since UCs don't reconstruct under ellipsis (Potts et al. 2009), our theory also predicts the absence of honorific meanings in ellipsis sites (cf. (14)) as a direct consequence of locating honorific content at the UC level.

Crucially, no reranking of ToDi and MQ needs to be posited for respect contexts: indirectness is only licensed when conventionalized UCs are in place. If a language lacks a particular UCC for an MQ-violating assignment, that assignment will be blocked by MQ. For instance, $\boxed{\text{1PL}}$ can, due to (16), pick out any entity that includes s_c or a_c . But, according to (20), an assignment where a $\boxed{\text{1PL}}$ index is mapped to a_c must be in a context where s_c

⁶ σ' is *at most as complex* as σ ($\sigma' \leq_c \sigma$) iff σ' can be obtained from σ by successive applications of deletion, contraction, or replacement of constituents with subconstituents or lexical terminals (Katzir 2007)

⁷ To make this concrete, consider the contrast between (i) and (ii), said by a nurse to a single patient.

(i) We=*you* need to sleep. (ii) You_{SG} need to sleep.

On the TC dimension, (ii) is more informative ($\{w : \exists g \text{ s.t. } \llbracket (ii) \rrbracket_t^g(w) = 1\} \subset \{w : \exists g \text{ s.t. } \llbracket (i) \rrbracket_t^g(w) = 1\}$), since (i) is compatible with worlds in which s_c , a_c , or both need to sleep, while (ii) requires only a_c . On the UC dimension, however, the Nurse We UCC restricts (i) to caretaking contexts, while (ii) is not restricted. So $\llbracket (i) \rrbracket_u^g \subset \llbracket (ii) \rrbracket_u^g$. Therefore, neither form is more informative than the other in the conjunctive sense of (19).

takes care of a_c . This explains why Nurse *We* is odd in contexts where s_c is distant, but not *ipso facto* performing a ‘caretaker’ role in the speech act itself, as we saw in (12) above.

While Wang’s approach overgeneralizes by predicting, *prima facie*, honorific readings whenever expressions with weaker presuppositions are used, our account is more restrictive in that it only predicts such readings: (i) when weaker $\pi/\#$ features are used; and (ii) when such features are enriched by UCCs. Due to our implementation in terms of constraints on assignments, we can also derive more fine-grained role restrictions on particular honorifics, which do not follow in an obvious way from general politeness considerations; e.g. the fact that s_c has to be a *caretaker* in English Nurse *We*. It is precisely by means of such UCCs that we capture cross-linguistic differences and idiosyncrasies in honorific inventories. For instance, the fact that English does not allow [3PL] pronouns to be used to refer to a_c (**Are they=you sick?*) is due to it not having a UCC that strengthens this index with a formality UC, like German does for *Sie*. Another example of this can be seen in Spanish, where Nurse *We*-like readings are only possible for null 1PL *pro*, and not for overt *nosotros*.

- (21) ¿Hemos (**nosotros=you*) tomado nuestras pastillas?
have.1PL we taken our pills

These lexeme-specific effects are highly unexpected if honorificity were derived mainly as a pragmatic inference. Hence, our account offers a more restrictive yet more empirically adequate alternative to pragmatic models like those of Wang (2023).

5. Conclusion

We have argued that the cross-linguistic regularities in a_c -honorification identified by Wang (2023) are real, but that a purely presupposition-based pragmatic account both undergenerates and overgenerates. Our hybrid pragmatic-conventional theory addresses both kinds of failure. Treating π and $\#$ features as part of complex indices rather than as presuppositions, we propose a more restrictive markedness hierarchy for person ($[2] < [1] < [3]$) that derives the typological asymmetry between a_c -inclusive and s_c -inclusive plurals and accommodates honorific uses of 1PL. The pragmatic principle ToDi supplies the impetus to select weak indices for the expression of distance, while remaining neutral with respect to valence (thereby extending naturally to anti-honorific uses of the same features). This yields a pool of $\pi/\#$ values from which honorifics can be recruited. The conventional component, in the form of language-specific UCCs, provides the semantic foothold that lets weak indices survive MQ-based competition with their more TC-explicit alternatives. Our theory thus reconciles Wang’s pragmatic approach with the existence of 1st person honorifics and with the conventionalized UCs that any adequate theory of honorific forms must recognize.

This dual architecture also illuminates the fine-grained meaning distinctions we observe across honorific systems. Because UCCs can encode arbitrary restrictions on the contexts in which a weak index is licensed, they are not confined to a single dimension of social meaning like politeness or formality. The Nurse *We* UCC in (20) restricts a_c -referring 1PL to caretaking relations; an analogous UCC for German patient-directed 3SG would restrict a_c -referring 3SG to provider-patient contexts; and the UCC for German *Sie* restricts a_c -

referring 3PL to contexts of general politeness/formality between s_c and a_c . What these forms share is the recruitment of a weak index licensed by ToDi; what distinguishes them is the specific class of contexts their UCCs pick out. Diachronically, this opens up a plausible pathway for the emergence of general politeness-based honorifics like *Sie*: an upward monotone expansion of the contextual restrictions imposed by UCCs, from narrow social roles (royalty, caretaker, provider, etc.) to broader and more abstract distance-implying relations (politeness, formality) (cf. Brown and Gilman 1960). On this view, generalized politeness need not be thought of as the defining property of honorifics, but as a late-stage limit point in their conventionalization.

Furthermore, if all honorifics begin life as narrowly social role-specific UCCs of the Nurse *We* type and only later generalize toward formality, then ϕ -featural honorifics may not differ in kind from the role honorifics (e.g. Japanese *sensei*) discussed by McCready (2019), only in how far their UC content has advanced in its path to abstraction towards general politeness. We leave the exploration of these hypotheses, and their implications for the diachrony of honorific systems more generally, for future work.

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